is obviously a great palace or a temple. One of the few major buildings that we can definitely identify is the ‘Great Bath’ in Mohenjodaro but even in this case we do not know if the structure was used for religious rituals (as in later Hindu temples), a bathing pool for the royal family or some completely different purpose.

Yet, the Harappan sites are remarkable for their attention to urban design and active municipal management. At its height, the Harappan civilization was very consciously urban. A large city like Mohenjodaro (now in Pakistan) may have had a population of around 40–50,000 people. Furthermore, we see meticulous town-planning in every detail—standardized bricks, street grids, covered sewerage systems and so on. Similarly, a great deal of effort was put into managing water. The solutions varied from city to city. Mohenjodaro alone may have had 600-700 wells. At Dholavira in Gujarat, water was diverted from two neighbouring streams into a series of dams and preserved in a complex system of reservoirs. [1] Many houses, even modest ones, have their own bathrooms and toilets connected to a drainage network that emptied into soak-jars and cess pits. The toilet commodes were made up of big pots sunk into the floor. Most interestingly, as historian Upinder Singh points out, the toilets came equipped with a ‘lota’ for washing up. [2] This must count as one of the most important and enduring of Harappan contributions to Indian civilization. Unfortunately, the toilet design did not survive quite as well as the lota.

DEALING WITH SLUMS AND TECTONICS

Dholavira is a good example of a large Harappan urban centre. It is on an island in the strange salt-marsh landscape of the Rann of Kutchh. At the centre of the settlement is a ‘citadel’ which consists of a rectangular ‘castle’ and a ‘bailey’. It is thought that the citadel contained the homes of the elite as well as public buildings. The castle, which is the oldest part of the city, was heavily fortified with thick walls and was probably meant to withstand military attack. Early scholars had a belief that the Harappan civilization was uniquely peaceful and that there are no signs of military activity. I